CHAPTER ELEVEN

Convergent Anti-Zionisms: The American Far Left and Far Right

Stephen H. Norwood

For decades the American far left has demonized Israel and the Zionist movement by recycling the shibboleths of the far right. The vitriolic denunciations that issue from the extremes of the political spectrum have been nearly indistinguishable.

Both the far left and far right have drawn on anti-Jewish concepts that had long been emphasized in Christian theology—that Jews were inordinately powerful; materialistic not spiritual, extracting their great wealth by exploiting gentiles, and engaged in the most egregious acts of cruelty. Christian theological antisemitism was so deeply embedded in Western culture that even the secular far left did not escape its influence. In a poem calling for Israel's destruction, a member of the Marxist-Leninist Black Panther Party, which received strong backing from white far leftists, drew explicitly on the New Testament charge that Jews had murdered Jesus: "kill every Jew we see. . . . Not another day should pass/Really, Without a foot up Israel's ass" because "that's where Christ was crucified."[1] The Maoist Revolutionary Communist Party's (RCP) characterization of Israel as America's "global hitman" resembled Christianity's image of the satanic Jew. According to the RCP, the Jewish state willingly executed anything its imperialist master, the United States, wanted done—no matter how "obscene. . . bloody. . .[and] obviously immoral."[2]

Leonard Dinnerstein began his major scholarly study of American antisemitism by stressing that "Christian culture so permeated American society" that it shaped the thinking of "even the unchurched." For much of the twentieth century numerous American localities made little or no effort to maintain the separation of church and state. Until the early 1960s public schools generally began the day with Christian prayer. Even today many American state universities open commencement ceremonies and athletic events with prayers to Jesus, and city council meetings often begin this way. Work and school calendars are structured around Christian holidays. During

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,